

How we Test



It looks good and the technology is glitzy, but does it do the job?

The Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) conducts a series of elaborate tests to evaluate the merit of each hardware and software product. To ensure that our readers have all the information they need to make an informed buying decision, engineers at DMTRC evaluate and review the latest hardware, software and technology services in accordance with the most up-to-date evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world.

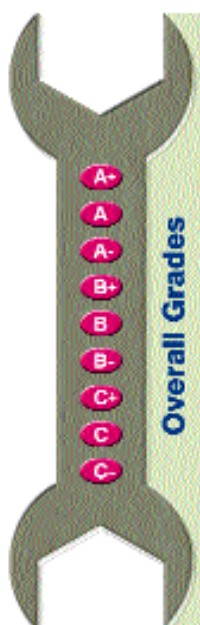
Comparison Tests

We use a dual rating system, the first of which is applied to the Comparison Tests in which we compare the performance of products within a particular category.

Each product is evaluated under different parameters such as performance, value for money, features, warranty and support, etc.

Weightages are then applied to the various test parameters according to their importance for that particular category of products.

These weightages are then used to arrive at an overall grade for each individual product. An overall grade of A+, therefore, indicates that the product is close to perfection.



The Awards

Digit awards outstanding products by selecting a Best Performance and Best Value winner in each comparison test. The winner of the Best Performance Award will be the product that scored the highest in the performance segment of our tests.

This award represents the best performing product in our tests and doesn't factor in any other parameter such as value for money, features, support, etc. The winner of the Best Value Award will be the product that scores the highest in our value for money parameter which is derived



taking into account the ratio of a product's performance and features to its price. The product winning this award offers good performance at a great price.

In Bazaar

The second part of the rating system is used to evaluate individual hardware and software products in the Bazaar section. The evaluation covers parameters such as performance, ease of use, value for money and the build quality/features of the product in question and then arrives at an overall rating.

Here each of these parameters is given a weightage of 25 per cent and is rated on a scale of 5, which is represented by arrows (▶).

The greater the number of arrows, the better the product. This simple five-point rating system is designed to give you an easy-to-interpret assessment of a product. For example, a product that receives an overall score of five arrows signifies an outstanding buy!

The 5-point Rating System used in Bazaar

▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Excellent: a brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Good: a good buy, better than most products in its category
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Average: reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Mediocre: does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Poor: has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application

In Test this Month

Branded PCs typically offer the right mix of price, performance and after-sales support and are thus ideal solutions for the first-time buyer or the corporate environment. This month's comparison test brings us face-to-face with 12 such offerings from companies such as Compaq and HCL. We took an application-based approach to evaluating them. We conducted real-world tests that covered office applications, productivity and gaming, and derived a Suitability to Task Index (STTI) that will help you choose a PC to fit your needs. To add spice to the PC mix, we also took a look at the latest Apple iMac.

Next, we tested three software suites—all-in-one solutions for system security, maintenance and recovering lost data. The suites came from the houses of Norton, McAfee and Ontrack and were evaluated for the features they offered as well as their performance under frequently used-tasks.

In the Bazaar section, we tested some of the latest hardware and software. The latest versions of both Red Hat Linux and CorelDRAW went under the Test Centre knife. The fastest Intel processor, the Pentium 4 2.8 GHz, also found its way among the products we tested, followed closely by possibly the fastest graphics card in India, the Gainward GeForce 4. To round up the range of products tested, we evaluated the ACI Impression notebook computer and a stand-alone disk-defragmentation tool—the Executive DisKeeper.